

Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Draft translation - not yet human-reviewed / مسوده ترجمه

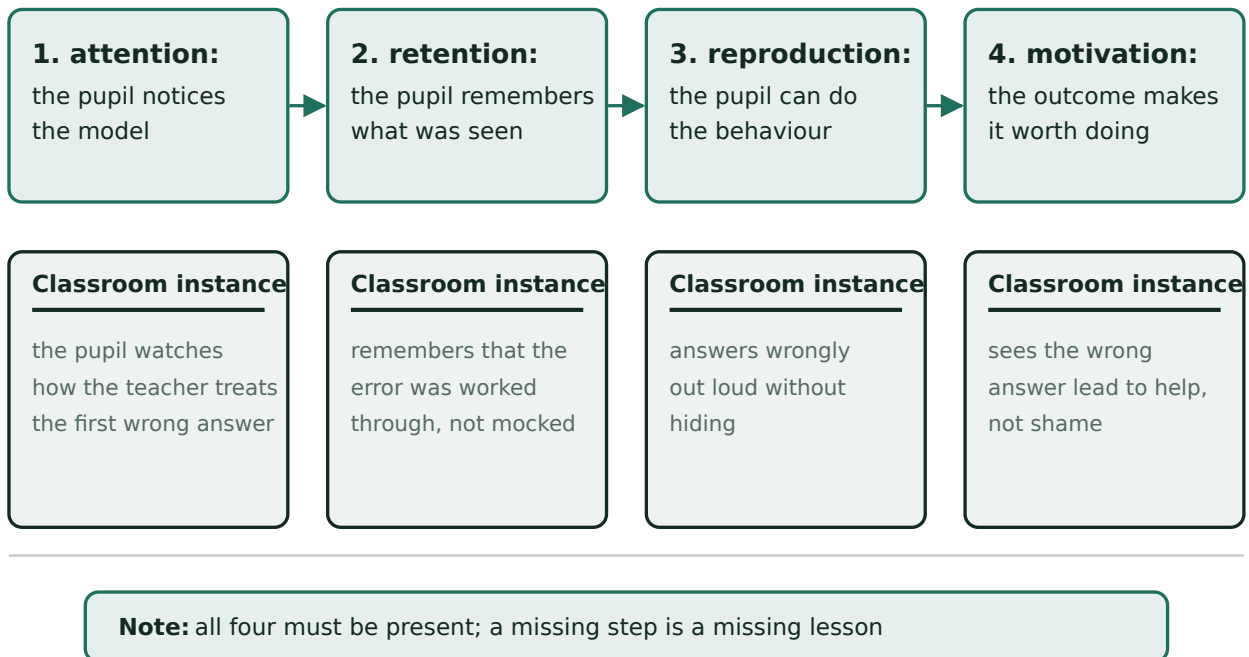
Topic 3.3 - Learning from others: Bandura's social learning theory

A real classroom situation

A new teacher, Miss Sadia, takes over Class 6 in March. In her first week, a pupil gives a wrong answer. She says, without thinking, "Good try - how did you get that?" and works through the error with the class.

Nothing about that exchange was a lesson. But by April, pupils in that class answer wrongly out loud, without the flinch the previous class showed, and when one pupil struggles, another sometimes says "good try" to *him*. The class has learned how wrong answers are treated, and the teacher never taught it.

That is the territory of this topic: the learning that runs through **other people**, observed rather than experienced, and the psychologist who mapped it - Albert Bandura.



textbook.com.pk

textbook.com.pk

Explanation

Bandura: learning by observation

Albert Bandura's social learning theory holds that humans learn a great deal by **observing others** - watching what they do and what happens to them - rather than only by doing and being reinforced themselves (Seifert & Sutton, 2009).

The observation is not passive recording. Bandura described it as an active process with steps, and the steps are a teacher's checklist.

Attention. The learner must notice the model. In a classroom, attention is engineered by salience: the teacher's first response to a wrong answer is one of the most attended-to events in the room, because every pupil is quietly checking what is safe here.

Retention. The learner must remember what was seen, in a form that can be used later. A vivid, structured episode - the "good try" exchange - retains better than a rushed one.

Reproduction. The learner must be able to do the behaviour. A pupil who watched a classmate defuse a quarrel may still fail to reproduce it if the words and moves are beyond them; complex behaviours need practice and often a script.

Motivation. The expected outcome must make the behaviour worth doing. This is where reinforcement re-enters - but with a twist Bandura made famous.

Vicarious reinforcement. The learner does not need to be reinforced personally; watching someone else be reinforced works almost as well. Research repeatedly shows that modelling desired behaviours is an effective way to teach new ones, especially when the model is seen as important, similar, or warmly related to the learner (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The pupil who watches a classmate praised for politeness becomes more likely to be polite. The reverse also holds: watching negative behaviour bring attention - from peers or from a teacher who cannot look away - reinforces the negative behaviour vicariously, in every pupil who saw it.

The misconception to clear now. "Observing violence on a screen teaches nothing." The classic laboratory demonstrations of observational learning - Bandura's inflatable-doll studies, in which children who watched an adult behave aggressively toward the doll reproduced much of that behaviour - are among the most replicated findings in psychology. What they show is not that every observer imitates everything; it is that the *capacity* is there, and that what is modelled, and what happens to the model, matter. The same mechanism that teaches a pupil to mock an error teaches the next one to say "good try". The theory is not a verdict on screens; it is a lens on models.

What the observational-learning research showed, and what it means for models

Two findings from the research tradition matter directly to a teacher.

Models are chosen, not assigned. The strongest models are perceived as important (the teacher, the head pupil), similar (the friend, the cousin), or warmly related (the teacher who knows your name) (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). A teacher is a model in every interaction whether or not they accept the office - the only choice offered is what is modelled.

The model's outcome is the lesson. Pupils read what happens to the model, not what the model says. When the loudest pupil gets the teacher's full attention and the quiet reply that is right gets only a tick, the class has learned two things, and the second one is not what the syllabus intended.

who the model is	what is being modelled	what strengthens or weakens the modelling
the teacher	how errors, questions and effort are treated	strongest model in the room: important, present daily consistency between words and outcomes
peers	how work is done, how others are treated	strong: similar and ever-present the classroom's visible norms, who gets attention
older pupils	habits, confidence, shortcuts	strong: admired and near in age what the school rewards them for
family	attitudes to school, to reading, to authority	strong: warm and long-standing whether school and home model the same things
screens and stories	behaviour repertoires, consequences as shown	strong: vivid, repeated, engaging whether consequences are shown honestly or glamorised

textbook.com.pk

textbook.com.pk

Activity: Map the models

In small groups, about 20 minutes.

Take one classroom you all know. For each of the five model sources in the figure - the teacher, peers, older pupils, family, screens - write one specific behaviour you believe is being modelled there, and one piece of evidence for your claim (something you saw, not something you assume).

Then answer the hard question: **which single model in that room is the teacher reinforcing most often, and for what?**

Check your understanding

1. Name Bandura's four observational-learning steps in order, with the classroom instance of each from this topic. (*Remember*)
2. Explain vicarious reinforcement in two sentences, with an example that is not from this topic. (*Understand*)
3. Why is the teacher's response to the *first* wrong answer of the year so powerful? Use at least two of the four steps. (*Apply*)
4. The loudest pupil gets the most attention; the quiet answer that is right gets only a tick. Name the two lessons the class has learned, and which one the syllabus intended. (*Analyze*)
5. A school bans phones and assumes screens no longer model anything. Using the model table, give two reasons why that assumption fails. (*Apply*)

Summary

Bandura's social learning theory shows that much of what pupils learn arrives by observation: attention, retention, reproduction and motivation must all be present, and reinforcement can be vicarious - watched, not felt. Models are chosen by importance, similarity and warmth, and the model's outcome, not the model's words, is what the observers read. A teacher is the strongest model in the room by default; the only question is what is being modelled, and what the room's attention trains.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the four observational-learning steps with an instance of each.
- ☐ I can explain vicarious reinforcement and give an original example.
- ☐ I can say what makes a model strong, and why a teacher cannot decline the office.
- ☐ I can read one real classroom for what its attention is reinforcing.

Try this at your practicum school

For one lesson, keep a two-column tally: on the left, every instance of pupil behaviour the teacher visibly notices; on the right, every instance the teacher lets pass. Do not judge the teaching. At the end, answer: what is attention being given for, and what is a pupil watching this learning?

Summative task

Write **250-300 words** on the new teacher's first week.

Miss Sadia's "good try" changed a class in six weeks. Using this topic, explain the mechanism: which steps of observational learning her response served, what was being vicariously reinforced, and why the effect spread to pupils she never spoke to. Then name one behaviour you would *deliberately* model in your own first week, and what outcome you would make sure the class observed for it.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Mechanism accuracy	The four steps and vicarious reinforcement are applied to the case, not just named.
Spread explained	The answer says why observers who were never addressed still learned. (<i>Analyze</i>)
Deliberate modelling	The chosen behaviour and its observed outcome are specific and realistic.
Plain, accurate writing	Terms used correctly; no padding; within the word count.

Further reading

- Seifert, K., & Sutton, R. (2009). *Educational Psychology* (2nd ed.), Chapters 2 and 10. University of Manitoba. CC BY.

<https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/educational-psychology>

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback